

Foreword

This study guide consists of my notes for the upper-level Georgia Tech graduate school course entitled “Advanced Operating Systems” (AOS). The motivation for compiling, editing, and publishing these notes was primarily to pass the course; a little more than half the class (over 300 students enroll per semester!) currently receives an A or B each semester, with a B as the minimum grade required if in the Computing Systems specialization, which I am. The notes were synergistic with my coursework; I was able to get an A thanks to these notes, along with dedicated efforts on projects. The proof is in the pudding; I started these notes a month and a half early in the summer before I started the class, due to the large span of material covered in the course, and was able to get an average, passing grade on the first exam (of three) by only reviewing these notes for the topics covered over the course of four days before the exam.

The exam format should be discussed in some detail to add context to the utility and purpose of these notes – there are three open-notes, open-internet, open-forum discussion (yes, you can ask and post questions to other students about the exam questions during the three-day exam period) spaced evenly throughout the AOS course. Each exam has questions posted before a weekend, then the students have two days to prepare their answers and a third day to “fill out the form” in the space of an approximately two-hour, proctored “exam” session. The final exam for this course, with an average amount of questions and points, required 5 pages of notes and writing to address all the questions adequately, amounting to a keyboard and memory performance during the exam session. These open-ended, short answer exams are notorious and widely considered the worst part of the class, requiring looking up trivia and facts and logical reasoning based on 48 papers throughout the span of the course. So this relatively concise note packet should serve as a supplement to the lectures and papers, enhancing understanding and making the studying, review, and lookup process that much easier.

Recover hope, all ye who enter here – the notes packet and the course are finite, regardless of how they seem on the outset. Good luck! I’ll be waiting for you on the other side!

